

DONOHUE GLOBAL HOLDINGS — The History of an Empire

Document 03 · Locked Canon · Corporate History, Structure & Succession

"They closed every door, so I built the house." — Alexander J. Donohue

At a Glance (as of January 3, 2005)

Item	Detail
Legal name	Donohue Global Holdings, Ltd. ("DGH")
Type	Privately held multinational holding company / global conglomerate
Founded	Donohue Enterprises, Inc. incorporated Monday, November 2, 1931. The DGH holding company was formed Monday, March 1, 1971.
Founder	Alexander Josiah Donohue (1905–1999)
Headquarters	Donohue Tower , 1 Donohue Plaza, 3200 Peachtree Road NE, Buckhead, Atlanta, Georgia 30305. 88 stories, completed 1992.
Chairman & CEO	Victor Donohue (since 1996)
Heir Apparent	Marc-Anthony Bullock (named 1996)
Valuation	\$10 trillion. The largest, most valuable company in the world.
Family fortune	More than \$2.5 trillion. The wealthiest family in the world.
Employees	About 4.1 million, directly and through controlled subsidiaries
Countries	171
Ownership	100% of voting control held by the Crown Trust (the Alexander & Simone Donohue Family Trust)
Motto	<i>Aedificamus quod negatum est.</i> ("We build what was denied.")

How the empire is built:

- **Donohue Global Holdings** is the **financial umbrella** above everything. It rarely operates companies directly.
 - It holds controlling interests through **subsidiaries, investment vehicles, trusts, and controlling stakes**.
 - **Donohue Enterprises** is the family's **operating empire**, the management company that runs the day-to-day businesses.
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Part One — The Boy From Americus (1905–1923)

- **Tuesday, March 14, 1905:** Alexander Josiah Donohue is born in a two-room sharecropper's cabin outside Americus, Sumter County, Georgia. He is the fourth of seven children of **Josiah and Hattie Donohue**.
 - He learns arithmetic by counting the landowner's cotton weights and catches the landowner cheating his father by 11 pounds a bale. When he is ten, he tells his father so. His father whips him for saying it out loud, then quietly starts weighing his own cotton.
 - **1921:** At 16, after the landowner's son beats his younger brother, Alexander leaves home. He walks and rides freight trains 135 miles to Atlanta with **three dollars sewn into his coat lining**. He later says that was the only money he ever kept "just in case."
 - **1921–1923:** He works as a redcap porter at Atlanta's **Terminal Station**. He sees Black travelers step off trains with no taxi willing to carry them and no hotel willing to house them, and he sees an industry that doesn't exist yet.
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Part Two — Sweet Auburn (1924–1945)

- **1924 — Donohue Transfer Company:** With \$200 in porter's tips, Alexander buys a used **Model T** and starts a jitney service carrying Black passengers from Terminal Station to Auburn Avenue. By 1926 he has **14 cars** and a moving-wagon line.
- **1927 — The Donohue House:** He buys a 12-room boarding house on Auburn Avenue. Every guest gets clean sheets, a hot breakfast, and a shoeshine. It's full every night.
- **October 1929 — The Crash:** Alexander doesn't trust white banks and has kept his savings in cash in a floor safe. When the market collapses, **he's one of the few men in Atlanta with money**. From 1930 to 1933 he buys **31 distressed Auburn Avenue and Old Fourth Ward properties** at pennies on the dollar.
- **Monday, November 2, 1931 — Donohue Enterprises, Inc. is incorporated** in the State of Georgia with a capital of \$41,000. Alexander is 26.
- **1932:** In New Orleans on business, Alexander walks into the **Toussaint Apothecary** on Dumaine Street to buy headache powder. He meets the pharmacist, **Simone Toussaint**, 21 and one of the first Black women licensed as a pharmacist in Louisiana. She charges him double because he's rude, and he comes back every day for two weeks.
- **Saturday, June 10, 1933: Alexander marries Simone** at St. Augustine Church in New Orleans. She moves to Atlanta and brings her formulas with her.
- **July 31, 1934:** Son **Theodore** is born.
- **1935 — Toussaint Laboratories:** Simone founds a hair- and skin-care company that sells door to door through a network of 3,000 "Toussaint Ladies" across 11 states. It later becomes **Donohue Health & Beauty**, the foundation of **Donohue Pharmaceuticals**.
- **May 30, 1936:** Son **Victor** is born.

- **Saturday, August 1, 1936 — The Hotel Donohue opens:** 150 rooms on Auburn Avenue with a rooftop supper club and a ballroom that seats 600. It appears in the first edition of *The Negro Motorist Green Book*. The Black press calls it "**the Waldorf of Sweet Auburn.**" Duke Ellington, Cab Calloway, Joe Louis, and Lena Horne stay there over the years.
- **1938 — Donohue Savings & Trust Company** is chartered. It lends to the Black homeowners and businesses that white banks turn away. It later becomes **Donohue Financial**.
- **1941–1945 — World War II:**
 - **Donohue Victory Services** wins contracts for laundry, catering, and transport at segregated military installations across the Southeast.
 - Alexander buys war bonds by the million, **on the condition that the newspaper photograph the purchase.**

Part Three — The Green Book Empire & The Savannah Betrayal (1946–1957)

- **1946–1952:** The Donohue Hotel chain spreads across the segregated South to Birmingham, Memphis, Charleston, Durham, Jackson, Nashville, and New Orleans. Each one is the best hotel a Black traveler can legally sleep in.
- **1948 — Donohue Mutual Life Insurance Company** is founded.
- **The Rival:** In Chicago, **Cornelius Smilley**, a former Pullman porter, has built the **Smilley Hotel Company**, the Green Book giant of the North (see Document 05). The two men are the most powerful Black hoteliers in America.
- **Friday, March 7, 1952 — The Savannah Betrayal:**
 - Alexander and Cornelius meet at a private house on Jones Street in Savannah to sign the merger that would create **Donohue-Smilley Hotels**, a coast-to-coast Black hospitality monopoly.
 - **At the last minute, Alexander tears up the contract.**
 - **The Donohue version:** Alexander learned Cornelius had secretly agreed to sell the combined company to a white-owned national chain. That chain would have fired every Black manager and turned the hotels into "colored annexes."
 - **The Smilley version:** Alexander used the negotiations to steal Cornelius's expansion plans, then walked away and built hotels in every one of Cornelius's target cities.
 - **The truth (LOCKED, SECRET):** *Both stories are partly true.* Cornelius was talking to the white chain, but only to get a better price out of Alexander. Alexander *did* use Cornelius's plans, which Simone copied from Cornelius's briefcase the night before. Simone kept the proof: "**The Savannah Letter,**" Cornelius's handwritten note explaining the bluff, which Simone intercepted and hid. **Alexander died without ever reading it.**
 - The two families have been at war ever since.

- **1955–1957:** Alexander begins secretly buying land in northwest Buckhead through white intermediaries (see Document 04, Belmont Crest).
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Part Four — Belmont Crest & the Movement (1958–1970)

- **1958:** Alexander and Simone found **Belmont Crest** (see Document 04).
 - **1960–1965 — The Civil Rights Years:**
 - The Donohues quietly bankroll the movement: **bail money for the 1960 Atlanta Student Movement sit-ins**, buses and hotel rooms for marchers, and legal fees for voting-rights cases.
 - Alexander never allows his name on a donor list. *"The Klan can read."*
 - Joan Mercer Donohue, not yet a lawyer, types movement legal briefs through the night while pregnant with Natasha (born June 2, 1961). She graduates from Howard Law in 1964.
 - **1964 — Civil Rights Act:** Legal segregation ends. Alexander's advisers expect the Green Book hotels to die as Black travelers go to the white chains. **Alexander bets the opposite:** that Black travelers will want **luxury**, not just permission.
 - **Monday, January 3, 1966 — Donohue Hospitality Group (DHG) is formed. Victor Donohue, 29, is named Chairman & CEO.** Theodore, 31, is not. The brothers' cold war begins.
 - **Saturday, April 13, 1968: The Donohue Atlanta** opens on Peachtree Street: 52 stories and 1,100 rooms, the most luxurious hotel in the South. The opening is held in quiet mourning nine days after Dr. King's assassination. Victor dedicates the lobby's eternal flame to him.
 - **1969–1970:** DHG opens The Donohue in New York (Fifth Avenue), Washington, D.C., and Nassau.
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Part Five — Going Global (1971–1989)

- **Monday, March 1, 1971 — Donohue Global Holdings, Ltd. is formed** as the parent holding company over every family business. The Crown Trust is created the same day to hold 100% of the voting shares forever.
- **1971:** Theodore becomes Fulton County District Attorney. Alexander calls it "a consolation prize with a badge."
- **1973 — The Oil Crisis:** DGH buys oil and gas stakes in Texas, the North Sea, and Nigeria. **Donohue Energy** is born.
- **1975–1979:** Hotels open in London (Park Lane), Paris, Lagos, Accra, Nairobi, Rio, and Tokyo. Victor refuses every offer to build in apartheid South Africa: *"We'll open in Johannesburg the day Mandela checks in."* (The Donohue Johannesburg opens in 1995, and Mandela attends.)
- **1979:** Joan Donohue is appointed to the U.S. District Court.
- **1980–1985:**

- **Donohue Media** launches the **Donohue Broadcast Network (DBN)**, a cable network, in 1983, and buys radio groups and magazines.
 - **Donohue Technologies** is founded in 1982, as the personal computer arrives.
 - **1985:** Robert Bullock founds Bullock & Associates. DGH becomes its first client.
 - **Monday, October 19, 1987 — Black Monday:** The market crashes 22.6% in one day. **Alexander, 82, repeats 1929.** DGH spends \$19 billion in 10 days buying blue-chip stakes at the bottom.
 - **1987:** Jasmine Donohue Olson takes her seat in Congress.
 - **1988–1989: Donohue Aerospace & Defense** is created through acquisitions. **Donohue Shipping & Logistics** buys a global fleet.
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Part Six — The Tower, the Codicil & the Millennium (1990–1999)

- **1992: Donohue Tower** opens in Buckhead: 88 stories, the tallest building in the Southeast.
 - **1990s:** DGH expands into pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, telecommunications, satellites, commercial real estate, agriculture, food and beverage, sports, and private equity.
 - **1996 — The Year of Succession:**
 - **Monday, June 3, 1996:** Alexander, 91, steps down. **Victor becomes Chairman & CEO of DGH. Natasha, 35, becomes CEO of Donohue Hospitality Group.**
 - **July–August 1996:** The **Centennial Olympic Games** come to Atlanta. DGH is a founding patron, and DHG hosts 60 national delegations.
 - **Sunday, October 13, 1996 — The Codicil:** At Sunday dinner at Donohue Manor, the family attorney reads **Alexander's Codicil to the Crown Trust** aloud. It names **Marc-Anthony Bullock, age 14, as Heir Apparent.** Alexander has watched the boy for years: his genius, his heart, and the fact that he once organized a strike by the Manor's household staff for better pay and won.
 - The room goes silent. Martin Olson, 15, walks out. Theodore stays and smiles.
 - **Friday, December 31, 1999, 11:58 PM: Alexander Josiah Donohue dies** at Donohue Manor, aged 94, holding Simone's hand. Marc-Anthony, 17, is at his bedside. Alexander's last words are to him: ***"Don't let them make you small."***
 - His funeral at Belmont Crest Chapel on **Friday, January 7, 2000**, draws two former presidents, 41 heads of state, and 12,000 mourners lining West Paces Ferry Road.
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Part Seven — The Modern Empire (2000–2005)

- **2000–2002:** After the dot-com crash, DGH buys distressed technology companies.
- **After September 11, 2001:** Donohue Aerospace & Defense and Donohue Technologies grow enormously. DGH is also among the **first contract clients of Blackwater Security International**

(founded 2002). The board votes 9–1 to hire the Heir Apparent's new company. The one "no" vote comes from a trustee who sits for Theodore's branch of the family.

- **2003:** DGH's valuation passes **\$8 trillion**.
 - **2004:** DGH's valuation reaches **\$10 trillion**. The company commits **\$25 billion** to rebuilding HBCU campuses nationwide.
 - **December 2004: Smiley International announces it will move its world headquarters from Chicago to Atlanta.** Victor reads the news, sets down the paper, and says only: *"Tell my mother."*
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The Crown Trust & the Rules of Succession (LOCKED)

- **The Crown Trust** (the Alexander & Simone Donohue Family Trust) holds **100% of DGH's voting shares**. Family members hold non-voting economic interests and receive dividends. Only the Trust votes.
- **The Crown Council** is the Trust's governing body. It has nine seats:

Seat	Holder (2005)
1	Simone Donohue (Founder's Seat, for life)
2	Victor Donohue (Chairman)
3	Joan Donohue
4	Theodore Donohue
5	Jasmine Donohue Olson
6	Natasha Donohue Bullock
7	Alvin Donohue
8	Marc-Anthony Bullock (Heir Apparent's Seat, non-voting until age 25)
9	Independent Trustee — Judge Harlan Whitcomb Jr. (the son of Alexander's white 1950s land intermediary)

The 1996 Codicil — Key Clauses

1. **The Heir Apparent** is Marc-Anthony Bullock.
2. **Age of Accession:** He takes a full vote and becomes **Vice Chairman-designate at 25 (January 5, 2007)**. He becomes Chairman when Victor retires, dies, or is incapacitated.
3. **The Disgrace Clause:** If the Heir Apparent is **convicted of a felony** or proven by a **two-thirds Council vote** to have "brought ruin or disgrace upon the name," the designation passes to the next eligible heir chosen by the Council.
 - **Martin's whole strategy is built on this clause.** Proving Marc is Sovereign would trigger it.
4. **The Line of Issue:** After the Heir Apparent, succession passes **"to his issue, of body, in order of birth."**

- **SECRET BOMB: Emma Smiley (born first by 6 minutes) is second in line to control the most valuable company on Earth.** Victoria is third.
- Martin, the Olsons, and Theodore's branch all fall behind two toddlers being raised by the rival family.

5. **The Founder's Veto:** While Simone lives, she can **veto any Council decision once per calendar year**. She has never used it.

Corporate Structure

Donohue Global Holdings, Ltd. is the umbrella. It holds, through subsidiaries, trusts, investment vehicles, and controlling stakes:

Division	Business	2005 Chief Executive
Donohue Enterprises, Inc.	Operating and management company for the whole empire	Victor Donohue
Donohue Hospitality Group	3,100+ hotels, resorts, casinos, cruise lines, private clubs in 140 countries. Brands include The Donohue, Crest Resorts & Spas, Auburn House, Toussaint Retreats, and Sovereign Casinos.	Natasha Donohue Bullock
Donohue Financial	Donohue Bank & Trust, Donohue Capital (private equity), Donohue Mutual Life, asset management	Harrison Lyle III
Donohue Energy	Oil and gas, pipelines, utilities, early solar and wind	Dr. Adaeze Nwachukwu
Donohue Pharmaceuticals & Health & Beauty	Drugs, biotechnology, hospitals, Toussaint beauty brands	Dr. Lorraine Beckwith
Donohue Technologies	Software, semiconductors, telecom, satellites	Kenneth Oyelaran
Donohue Media	DBN cable network, film studio (Crest Pictures), 212 radio stations, magazines, record label (Auburn Records)	Franklin Cummings (board); President: Monique Sayles
Donohue Aerospace & Defense	Aircraft, avionics, government systems	Gen. (Ret.) Curtis Holloway
Donohue Shipping & Logistics	1,400-ship fleet, ports, freight rail, air cargo	Olufemi Adebayo
Donohue Realty	Commercial towers, land, Belmont Crest Holdings	Reginald Donohue (Theodore's son; a contested appointment)
Donohue Foods & Agriculture	11 million acres of farmland, beverages, grocery brands	Evelyn Stroud
Donohue Sports & Entertainment	Stakes in international football clubs, arenas, the Crest Classic golf tournament	Alvin Donohue (a figurehead title)
The Donohue Foundation	Global philanthropy	Joan Donohue , Chair

(Non-family executives are supporting characters who can be developed later.)

The Donohue Foundation — "Spare No Expense"

- **Endowment:** \$420 billion. **Annual giving:** more than \$30 billion. It is the most generous charitable institution in human history.
 - **Signature programs:**
 - **The Alexander Scholars:** full rides plus a \$50,000 annual stipend for 25,000 students a year, with priority for HBCUs.
 - **Simone's Table:** free groceries and pharmacies in 3,000 food deserts.
 - **The Hattie Donohue Housing Trust:** down-payment grants for first-generation homeowners, named for Alexander's mother.
 - **Crest Clinics:** free hospitals across the rural South, Africa, and the Caribbean.
 - **The Mercer Justice Project:** Joan's program, providing free appeals for the wrongfully convicted.
 - **The rule:** No Donohue charity event ever uses a paper plate.
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Corporate Culture & Traditions

- **Sunday Dinner at the Manor:** Every Sunday at 4:00 PM. Attendance is expected. Business is forbidden at the table, which means everyone talks business in the hallway.
- **The Founder's Breakfast:** Every March 14 (Alexander's birthday), every DGH employee worldwide gets a free hot breakfast and a shoeshine.
- **The Three Dollars:** Every Donohue child gets three dollars in a sewn pouch on their 16th birthday. Marc-Anthony still carries his.

See Document 04 for Belmont Crest, and Document 05 for the Smilley rivalry.